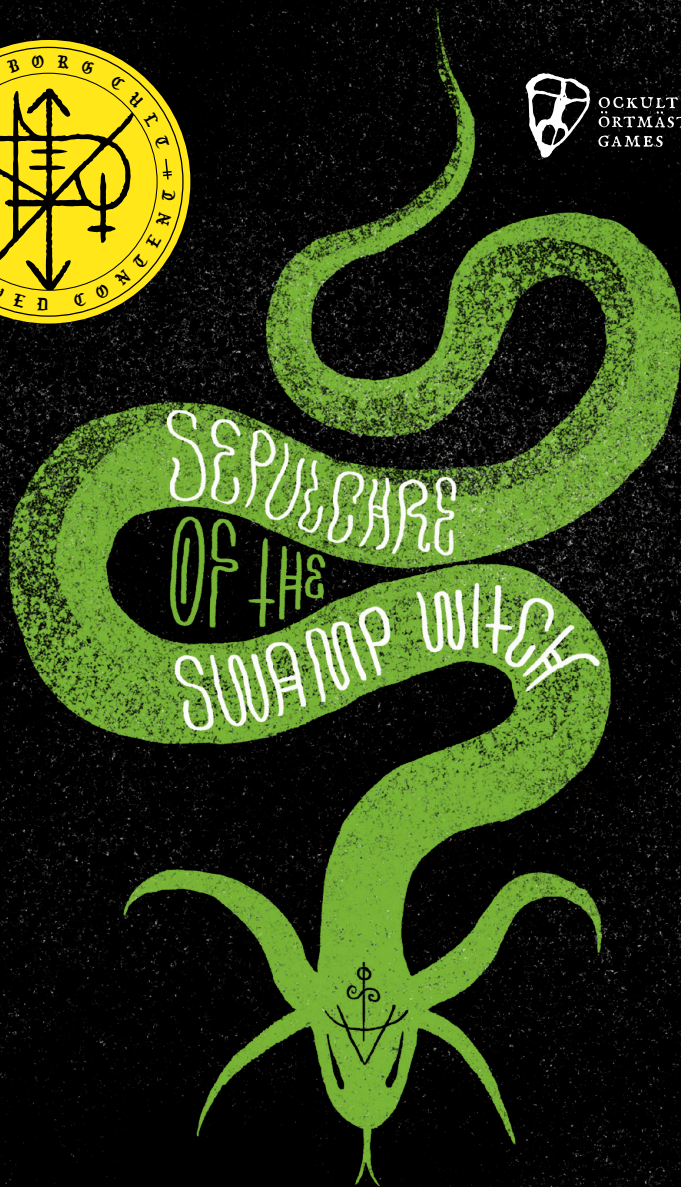




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A SCENARIO FOR

MÖRK BORG

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East of Lake Onda IN THE SUFFERING SWAMP

is the Swamp Witch's ancient sepulchre and an altar of dead roots covered in lost symbols. They say if certain forbidden words are chanted at it, any wish is fulfilled. Even stopping the approaching Doom is not outside the powers of the Swamp Witch's altar.

You stumbled on these forbidden words on a murdered messenger wearing mad King Fathmu IX's crest in a ditch. You just need to get past the Strange Serpent Drug Cult lairing in the ancient tomb and reach the altar.

You also heard...(d6)

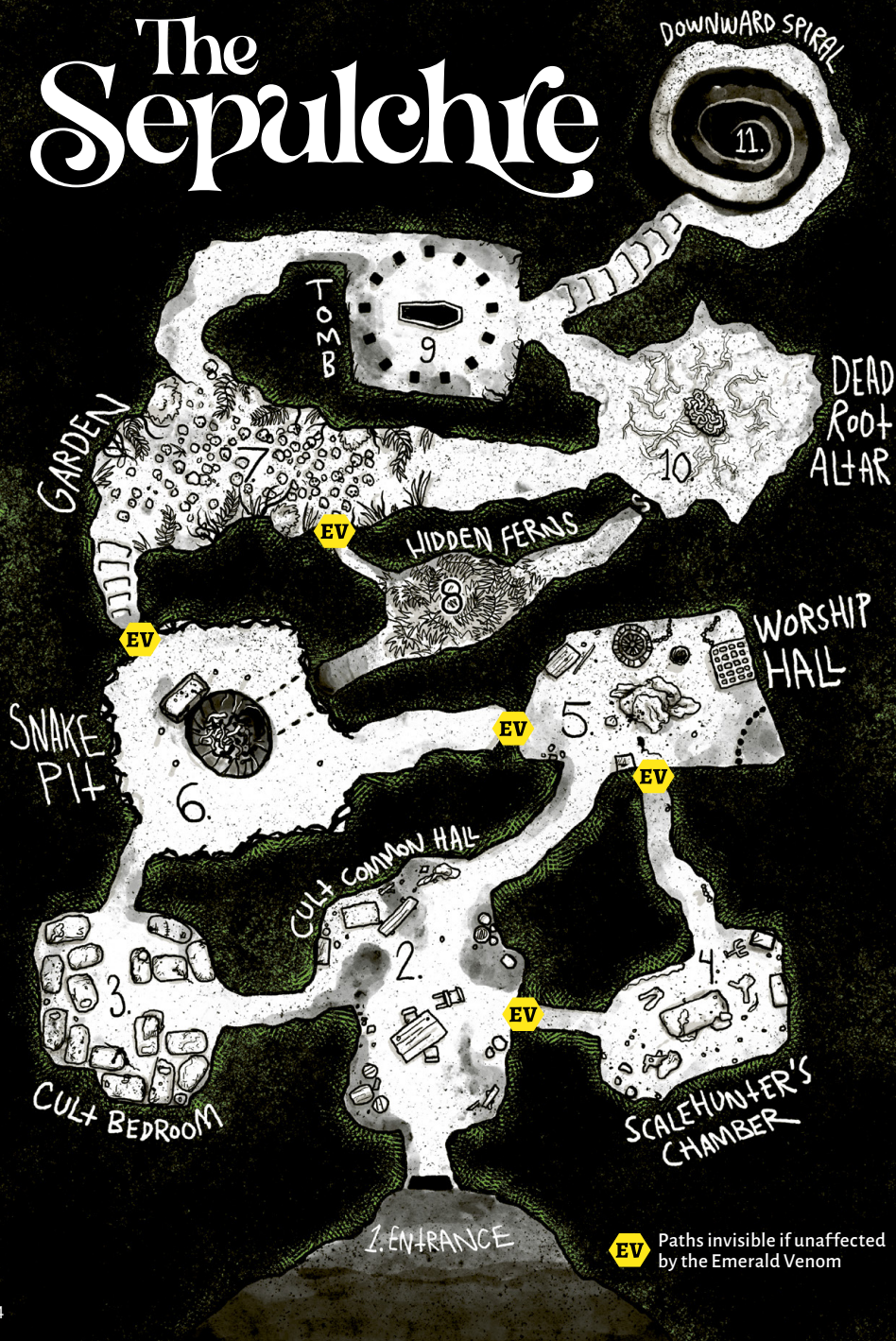
1. Of **snakes** guarding the entrance. Whatever you do, **do not harm them!**
2. The cult **kidnaps people**, desecrating the Swamp Witch's altar with blood and viscera.
3. Chanting those forbidden words **backwards** *raises the Swamp Witch from the dead.*
4. Of **occult treasures** buried deep within, guarded by slime-covered amphibians.
5. Of **deep-pocketed merchants** trading illicit goods with the cult.
6. Entrants risk catching a **psychic parasite**. To prevent it from spreading, isn't it better to simply kill everyone and maybe also burn the swamp? Yes. It's the only way to be sure.

The Strange Serpent Drug Cult

formed when **Ueth the Scalehunter** found the **Emerald Serpent** while already intoxicated by a fungus-and-swamp-water brew. Stunned, he did nothing as the serpent bit him, mixing brew and venom into a permanent hallucinogen in his bloodstream. He had visions of sacred snakes promising eternal happiness after the world's end. All he must do is to spread a message of love and joy until then—and make a **sacrifice to the serpents every three days**. He returned to his village of Nechdorf preaching happiness, love, sex and drugs, asking everyone to join him in his newfound swamp paradise. A few did; the rest were later kidnapped and sacrificed in the name of eternal love.



The Sepulchre



1. Sunken Entrance

- **Stone gate** standing in 5' of green water.
- A large **Emerald Serpent** sits on a floating leaf.
 - ❑ She **speaks**, informing those approaching that the door opens only to those allowing her to bite them.
 - ❑ This is a half-truth: her bite injects a **hallucinogenic venom** that also works as a key, but the door also opens if she's slain. She attacks anyone trying to force the door.



2. Cult Common Hall

- Upward slope leads to a **moist cave** with crappy furniture and puddles of swamp water. Smells of algae, mold and burnt bread.
- 50% chance **D4+3 cultists** are present, dining on bread and grilled gator.
- The path to the Scalehunter's Chamber is **invisible** to those unaffected by the **Emerald Venom** until someone who sees the path steps into it.
 - ❑ The same applies to further EV doors and portals in other parts of the sepulchre.

EV *Those tripping see sparks in the puddles, new green leaves growing from the rock ceiling, and a shining pathway to the Scalehunter's Chamber (4).*

Emerald Serpent

HP 8 Morale— No armor

Bite D2 + Emerald Venom

► **Lightning reflexes** Attacks thrice each round, and melee attacks against her use Agility DR16 instead of Strength.

► **Emerald Venom** Test Toughness DR12 or be afflicted (no test if willingly bitten). Everything turns chromatic. Fire burns with colors never seen before: jale, dolm, and ulfire. Spectral leaf buds grow from dead matter. Everything is kaleidoscopic. Nature sings just for you. There is beauty in the world. Certain truths become clear to you. You get **–1 on initiative** (if using individual initiative) and **fumble on 1–3** for the duration of the 7-day-long high. You also **perceive some things differently** here. (See EV in each room description.)

Strange Serpent Drug Cultist

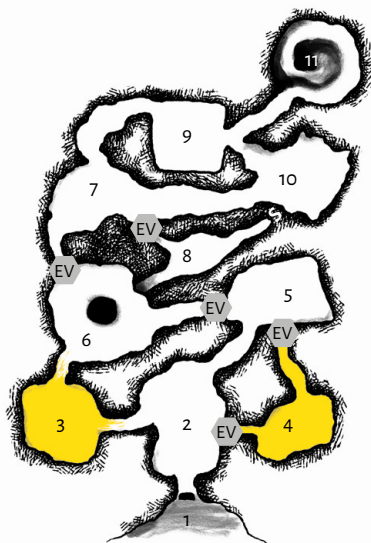
HP 4 Morale 4

Gatorskin vestment –D3

Knife or club D4

► **Drug-addled** Immune to mind-affecting powers.

The cultists recognize Emerald Venom in people, assuming the party are new disciples if more than two are tripping. If so, they are friendly or helpful; otherwise, roll Reaction. The cultists are unaware of the Swamp Witch or her tomb but know plenty about an altar and fulfilled wishes, though they are wary to speak too much about it.



Ueth the Scalehunter

HP 20 Morale 6 Gatorskin robe –D4

Jagged spear D8 + bleed

► **Bleed** D2 damage every round for d4 rounds after being hit by the spear, ignores armor.

The *permanently high* cult leader is the real deal—a complete believer in his serpentine visions and would very much like the newcomers to join him in worship. If they seem unwilling, he tries to subdue them for use as sacrifices. If his morale breaks, he tries to escape to the Worship Hall (5) for cultists' aid. He has heard the rumors of the Swamp Witch buried somewhere in here but hasn't gone farther than the Garden, where he felt threatened and turned back.

3. Cult Bedroom

- Twenty or so mold-covered **straw mattresses**
- **D6+4 resting cultists** who assume the party belongs here unless they are blood-splattered or charging, weapons drawn.

EV A large spectral lizard rests atop a green pillow in a corner. If approached, it lazily retreats into the wall and disappears. The pillow is a pouch with 2D4×10 silver.

4. Scalehunter's Chamber

- The small openings leading to Ueth's chamber are **only visible for those on Emerald Venom**.
- Dried gators hang from the ceiling, drawings of snakes made with bodily fluids on the walls, well-used mattresses on the floor.

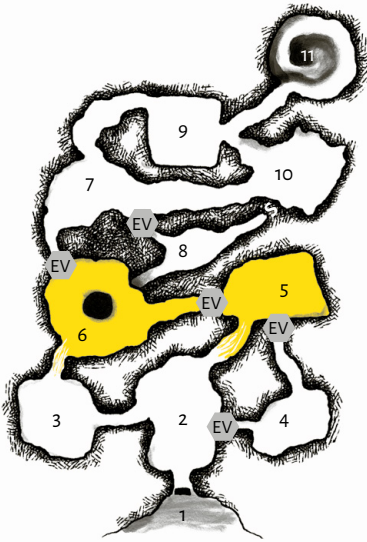
☐ Among the dirty rags is a **scroll** with Ueth's gospel scribbled on one side and the Power **Slithering Strangulation** on the other.

EV There are three large snakes slithering upside down on the ceiling. They do not wish to be disturbed and respond to threats by attacking twice the same round for D4 damage and then disappear.

UNCLEAN SCROLL: SLITHERING STRANGULATION

D4 rainbow colored, ethereal boa constrictors emerge from the ground and capture one creature each for D8 rounds, dealing D2 damage each round. Attacking a constricted creature in melee comes with a 50% risk of the snake changing target to the attacker.





Forked-Tongue Devotee

HP 9 Morale 9

Gatorskin hood and vestment –d4

Forked dagger D4 + poison, or

Viperspit Agility DR12 or blinded.

► **Poison** Test Toughness DR10 or become infected and drowsy, raising the difficulty of all attack and defence tests by +2 for D4 hours.

► **Viperspit** Test Agility DR12 to avoid being blinded D3 rounds.

These are the most fanatic of Ueth's followers and will die for him if asked. They will not allow any suspicious behaviour in the Worship Hall (5). They speak with a burning passion and wicked lisp.

5. Worship Hall

- **Stained blankets** on the floor, used while practicing Ueth's gospel of free love.
 - Among them is a **ruby ring** inscribed with the name Klopstock—worth 200 silver to most merchants, but if brought to Schleswig, the only surviving Klopstock family member pays five times as much.
- **Three large metal cages** with five starved prisoners, horrified and ripe for sacrifice.
 - Travelers and nearby villagers with nothing but a will to be set free.
- **D4+2 fanatical Devotees** guard the sacrifices, and there's a 50% chance that they're joined by **D4 regular cultists** enjoying themselves.

EV The paths to both the Snake Pit and the Scalehunter's Chamber appear as a portal of green vines and a crevasse behind a flutter of butterflies, respectively.

6. Snake Pit

- Grime-covered **stone altar** above a **20' pit full of snakes**. Walls and ceiling covered in dead roots.
- **A Forked-Tongue Devotee** is feeding the snakes.
 - Most serpents are harmless and won't come near open flame, exempting another **Emerald Serpent** who warns anyone without Emerald Venom in their blood that they won't reach their goal without letting him bite them.
 - Underneath the snakes are a dozen human **skeletons**. A protrusion in the pit's wall looks like a stone block from above and **hides a narrow tunnel** to the Hidden Ferns.

EV A giant snake's head with a vertical mouth sits in the northern wall. If approached, it telepathically informs the PCs that Ueth forbids any cultist from going farther. It opens its mouth, allowing passage to the Garden if someone claims to not be a cultist or not care about the rule.

7. Garden

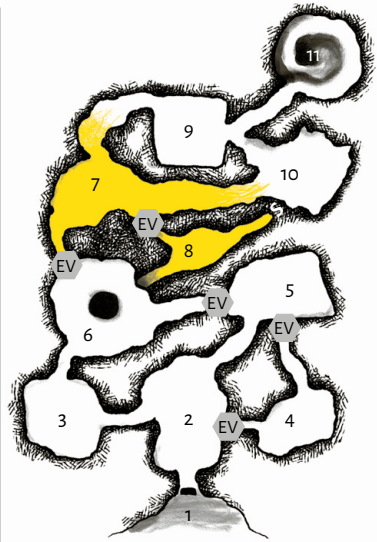
- **Luminescent flowers** grow from the ceiling.
- Strange, ancient **symbols** are carved into the walls.
- The ground is covered in (mostly human) **skulls**.
 - ❑ A few are wide and violet with three eye sockets and a mouth capable of swallowing a person whole.
 - ❑ Hidden among them is a **small bag** containing 750 silvers' worth of gems.

EV *The shifting symbols, if carefully studied, change into a familiar alphabet: “The eternal avatar here guards, protecting both those above and below from famine, plague, war, death and extinction.” A giant flower opens when approached, revealing the path towards the Hidden Ferns.*

8. Hidden Ferns

- **Luminescent ferns** cover the ground and walls.
 - ❑ **The Croaking Trident** is hidden beneath ferns along the east wall.
- **Venomous adders** guard the path from the Snake Pit, attacking anyone unaffected by Emerald Venom. Test Agility DR12 or be bitten for D4 damage.

EV *Dead ethereal snakes are piled up along the east wall, especially atop the Croaking Trident.*



The Croaking Trident

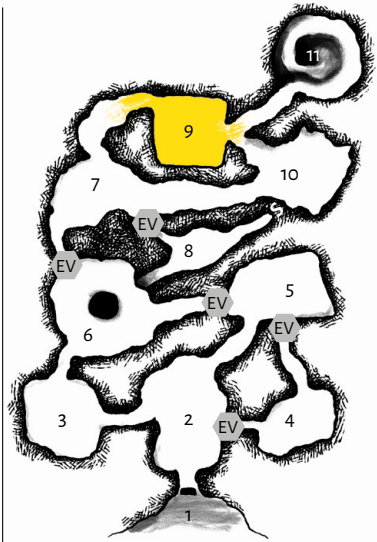
A two-handed trident surrounded by pandemonic energy, it deals D10 regular + D4 pandemonic damage. Each living creature it slays gradually turns the wielder into a mad amphibian humanoid. The changes start subtly, but **after 5 kills**, people begin noticing the bulging eyes, the slimy sweat and discoloration of the skin. **After 8 kills**, the wielder has a natural –D2 armor due to their rubbery skin, and croaks between their words as they sometimes incoherently speak. **At 13 kills**, the transformation is complete, and nothing remains of the person but chaotic amphibian rage, madness and violence.



9. Tomb

- **A cloud of moths** seems to fill the room but are, on closer inspection, just circling:
- A ring of **13 obelisks** carved with endless spiraling snakes surrounding in turn:
- A lidless and empty **sarcophagus**.
- **The Swamp Witch** floats 2' from the ground at the far end, obscured by moths.

EV A whirlwind of colors, most previously unknown and alien. The droning noise of hundreds of souls screaming in ultra-slow motion fills the room. Tentacles of pulsing light grow from the sarcophagus towards the corridors leading to the Dead Root Altar and Downward Spiral.



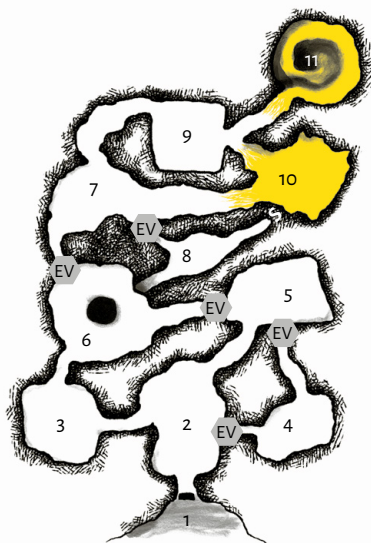
THE SWAMP WITCH

HP 30 Morale — Ethereal barrier —D4 Lunar Zweihänder D12 + radiance

- **Radiance** The Lunar Zweihänder is made from moonlight, ignores all non-magical armor, and each hit fills the room with radiant light. Everyone within 50' tests Presence DR12 or takes D4 damage.
- **Eternal** As long as the Dead Root Altar stands, the Swamp Witch does not die at 0 HP but instead evaporates and reforms in the sarcophagus with full health 3D6 rounds later. Should the Swamp Witch truly die, the Emerald Serpents, the barrier blocking the Downward Spiral and all Emerald Venom hallucinations disappear forever.

The Swamp Witch takes the form of a scraggy figure dressed in a green robe. Instead of skin, she is covered in multi colored scales, and where her head should be is just black smoke and two bright diamond eyes. On her back is a shining greatsword longer than she. She floats 2' above the ground.

She communicates telepathically with either whispers or screeches. She would very much enjoy seeing the party make a wish and pledge at the altar and can instruct them how, whispering seductive promises of individual gains to them if they just find an unwilling person to pledge. After all, would all members of the party truly be missed in this world?



Srolki

HP 25 Rubbery skin

and Metal armor –D6

Claws D6×2 and Bite D10 or Croak

► **Slimespeed** Attacks twice each round with their claws and bites or croaks once. Attack and defence tests are DR14 against Srolki.

► **Croak** A loud croak stuns and deafens anyone within 20' unless they test Presence DR12.

Yaoxl

HP 27 Rubbery skin –D3

Ranseur of the Maelström D10 + drain

► **Drain** The ranseur transfers D4 HP from the target to Yaoxl on each hit.

► **Powers** Can wield the following powers up to D3 times per day each: *Metzhuotl Blind Your Eye*, *Nine Violet Signs Unknot the Storm* and *Roskoe's Consuming Glare*.

10. Dead Root Altar

- Walls, ground and ceiling covered in **dead roots**. A group of roots stand up, shaped like an **altar**.
□ Lost symbols are carved into the altar.
- Loose bits of **dead wood**, **vaguely resembling humans**, are spread around the room.
- It is **dead silent**: not a fly lives here.
- It's possible to squeeze through a pair of roots on the south wall to enter a **tight passway** to the Hidden Ferns.

EV *The altar is surrounded by a golden glow. Small budding leaves are spread around on all roots, but the loose bits of wood are completely dead and barren. The altar reads "Without cost, no wish comes true. Make a pledge unwilling, and reality bends for you. Stay then silent."*

11. Downward Spiral

- A **black pit** with a narrow ledge circling it downwards and downwards and downwards.
- If the Swamp Witch is alive and the altar is intact, a **magical barrier** blocks anyone from going farther down than 30'.
- **Two antediluvian, three-eyed, humanoid toads** stand guard, hidden 50' below.
□ **Srolki and Yaoxl** have guarded this pit for centuries, during which they have been partners, enemies, lovers and allies.
□ They are willing to do almost anything to get their hands on the **Croaking Trident**.
□ If the barrier is broken and one lives to tell the tale, **more of their kind** will appear in the area over the next d20 days.
- **Further down**, great caverns open up, and somewhere deep are entire cities of these creatures.

EV *Bubbles are slowly rising from the pit, and it almost sounds like waves in the distance. An opaque, shining green barrier blocks the path.*

Wishes



A wish made while an **unwilling human** is sacrificed on the altar somehow comes true. The exact phrasing is important, and the GM is encouraged to find loopholes and possible complications. *Asking for riches* may result in stolen treasures someone already seeks, etc. *Asking for the world not to end* only delays the inevitable; do not roll on The Calendar of Nechrubel the next time a Misery is supposed to activate. No matter the wish, the sacrifice dies screaming as their soul is pulled from their body and into the altar—all that remains is dead wood. Roll D6 below to see what happens after a wish is made.

1. The altar temporarily cracks, weakening the Downward Spiral's barrier **long enough for Srolki and Yaoxl to cross**. No further wish can be made for d12 months.
2. The altar cracks straight through, **weakening the Swamp Witch to 1 HP**, making it possible to kill her permanently. A **Misery** instantly activates. Nothing can ever restore the altar.
3. The room fills with chaotic magical energy. **All scrolls of Power shift**. Test Presence for each scroll someone carries. If the test fails, roll a random new Power to replace the previous one. No further wish can be made for D10 days.
4. **Seasons change**: if it is summer, it becomes winter, etc. No further wish can be made for D6 weeks.
5. **Time slows down in the dungeon**: the GM rolls until a Misery occurs. A number of days passes equal to the number of rolls made. No further wish is possible until as many days have passed once more.
6. The altar deems the pledge unworthy and **drains the energy from everyone in the room**, resulting in a loss of D4 from their maximum HP. No further wish is possible until as many months have passed as total HP were lost.

A wish made with a **willing sacrifice**, such as a character giving themselves up for the greater good, is *punished*. The would-be sacrifice is thrown into the air for D10 damage while the wish-maker must test Toughness DR16 or suffer 2D8 damage and be paralyzed for D6 rounds. This also angers the Swamp Witch, who appears sword in hands.